

Speaker 1 [00:00:00] Alright. Do you agree to participate in the study?

Speaker 2 [00:00:04] Yes, I agree.

Speaker 1 [00:00:07] Alright. I'll start with a few demographic questions. How old are you?

Speaker 2 [00:00:12] [30-35].

Speaker 1 [00:00:13] [30-35]. How long have you been with your partner?

Speaker 2 [00:00:17] About [1-5] years.

Speaker 1 [00:00:19] Alright. Do you have any children?

Speaker 2 [00:00:23] Cats don't count, right?

Speaker 1 [00:00:25] Hehe (laughs), well, we can count them.

Speaker 2 [00:00:26] I don't have human children.

Speaker 1 [00:00:28] Okay. Who do you live with at home?

Speaker 2 [00:00:33] Well, right now, I'm at my family home with my mom and dad, but I mostly live in [City]. My residence is also in [City]. When visiting, I live with my partner. You can base your research on either.

Speaker 1 [00:00:49] What is your main source of income?

Speaker 2 [00:00:55] I work as a [occupation].

Speaker 1 [00:01:00] Alright. How would you like us to refer to your partner? Partner, lover, spouse?

Speaker 2 [00:01:06] You can say partner; it doesn't matter. We use partner as a more gender-neutral term.

Speaker 1 [00:01:16] Now, I'll ask some questions in a romantic context. Can you tell me your meeting story and how your relationship started?

Speaker 2 [00:01:24] How did our relationship start? We were actually part of a mutual friend group. At that time, [Name] was the president of [Group]. We first met through an animal rights community. Later, I had another partner, but we had a mutual acquaintance within the friend group. So, if you look at it overall, we've had about an [6-10]-year friendship. During that period, I broke up with my partner and wasn't seeing anyone for a while. Then we had a phone conversation when I was considering moving back to [Location]. We talked about meeting up, and one day he called, and we met. I felt a strong attraction to him, and I told him this. he felt the same way. Initially,

[redacted]. Later, it evolved into a romantic relationship. We started to meet more frequently, spending nights at each other's places, and it eventually turned into a romantic relationship. And now it's been about [1-5] years.

Speaker 1 [00:02:56] So, what processes or factors do you think influenced the transition to a romantic relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:03:07] We had a complicated period. [Redacted]. Being open and honest about what we wanted played a significant role. Seeing that we were on the same page was eye-opening for me.

Speaker 1 [00:04:36] How would you compare the quality of your relationship to your friends' relationships?

Speaker 2 [00:04:45] All our friends?

Speaker 1 [00:04:47] Yes, your friends.

Speaker 2 [00:04:53] Specifically, we talk a lot about relationships, and it's a topic we enjoy. We feel lucky compared to our friends because one of the most significant issues we see in other relationships is extreme jealousy, even among our more open-minded friends. For instance, my close friend was very surprised by our open relationship and our open communication. Many people don't have this kind of open communication. I see communication breakdowns as the main issue in many relationships. Most of our friends are in monogamous relationships, and even if it's not discussed, it's accepted as the norm. In contrast, we built our relationship on open communication and agreed from the start that we didn't want monogamy. This kind of relationship construction is something I don't see in others. They tend to be more possessive and restrictive.

Speaker 1 [00:07:19] Can you elaborate on what you mean by open communication and give some concrete examples?

Speaker 2 [00:07:26] Sure. During the time I was getting close to [Name] and had another partner, I didn't hide anything from either side. I had come out of a stressful situation with my previous partner, and being cheated on was a battle for me. I wanted to be honest about what I wanted, and [Partner's Name] was the same. For example, in a truly open relationship, if we feel jealous or have concerns, we talk about it directly. [Name] once felt jealous of my other partner, and we talked about it openly. We expressed our feelings, and this level of honesty was refreshing. We continue to have this open communication, which has been crucial for our relationship.

Speaker 1 [00:10:25] Can I ask how many romantic relationships you've had in the past?

Speaker 2 [00:10:33] It's a bit complicated. I've had [1-5] romantic relationships that I consider significant. There were other shorter or less serious ones, but [1-5] main ones.

Speaker 1 [00:11:04] You mentioned this a bit earlier, but for the purpose of the project, how would you evaluate the quality of your current relationship compared to your previous ones?

Speaker 2 [00:11:19] When I started my relationship with [Partner's Name], including the complicated parts, it's been [1-5] years. At [31-35], I saw how healthy a relationship could be. I had tried to build open and equal relationships before, but I realized the other side wasn't always supportive. My first long relationship lasted [6-10] years, and it was filled with psychological abuse. Comparing that to my current relationship, it's much higher quality because we respect each other's space, don't feel burdened, and openly communicate. Even when we need alone time, we talk about it. For example, recently, [Partner's Name] said, "I need some alone time, will it bother you?" and I said, "Of course not, it's a need." This level of respect and understanding is something I've never experienced before.

Speaker 1 [00:14:08] Can you give more concrete examples of respecting space and why it's important for a relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:14:22] During the period of psychological abuse, I was heavily isolated. Even when I wanted to do something alone, I was manipulated into having my partner there. This kind of control and lack of space can lead to a very unhealthy dynamic. In my previous relationship, when my partner gained more independence, it led to jealousy and control issues. Respecting space is crucial to prevent these issues. With [Partner's Name], we allow each other to have our own time and activities, which keeps our relationship healthy. This prevents us from feeling overly burdened and keeps the relationship balanced.

Speaker 1 [00:19:28] What elements make a relationship high-quality for you?

Speaker 2 [00:19:40] Communication is the first thing. Looking back, it's the one thing I see missing in most relationships. Being able to talk and be understood is essential. Second, respecting each other's space. Third, respect itself. It might sound cliché, but showing respect, empathy, and compassion goes a long way. Even when tensions rise, taking a moment to calm down and then talk about it is incredibly important. [Partner's Name] taught me not to close off and sulk but to communicate my feelings. This has made a huge difference in our relationship.

Speaker 1 [00:24:59] You mentioned not feeling conscious in past relationships. What elements create a conscious relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:25:14] By conscious, I mean being aware of your actions and their impact. I realized in past relationships that my excessive giving was due to a lack of self-respect and self-love. Through psychological support, I understood that I was giving too much because of low self-worth. In my relationship with [Partner's Name], I became aware of this and worked on it. For example, early on, [Partner's Name] would buy me small gifts when we argued. I asked him to stop because it felt manipulative. We

needed to address the issues directly rather than masking them with gifts. This awareness has helped us build a healthier relationship.

Speaker 1 [00:30:05] So, integrating your previous answers, would you say strong, high-quality relationships are characterized by open communication, respect, and not harming each other?

Speaker 2 [00:30:27] Yes, for me, based on my experiences and observations, that's true.

Speaker 1 [00:30:32] Your previous answers were detailed, but since it's the main topic of the project, I'd like to ask a bit more.

Speaker 2 [00:30:40] Sure, I think I covered everything, but go ahead.

Speaker 1 [00:30:44] No problem, you can talk as much as you like. Everything you say is important to us.

Speaker 2 [00:30:49] Thank you.

Speaker 1 [00:30:50] What are the most important things for you in a relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:30:58] Communication and the instinct not to harm. It's interesting how love can turn into harm in relationships. One moment someone is the best person in the world, and the next, when they hurt you, you want to hurt them back. I can't understand that. So, communication, knowing what you want, avoiding manipulation, and giving space are key for me.

Speaker 1 [00:32:17] What is aşk for you?

Speaker 2 [00:32:21] This is something I've thought a lot about and discussed with [Partner's Name]. I used to think aşk was all-consuming, but now I see it differently. The concept of aşk as society teaches us, like in TV shows, isn't real. For me, aşk has evolved to mean genuinely liking someone, having a safe space with them, and feeling at peace. With [Partner's Name], I feel true aşk and sevgi. It's about being healthy mentally, not feeling pressured or having to explain everything.

Speaker 1 [00:35:10] Can you elaborate on what you mean by a safe space?

Speaker 2 [00:35:18] In past relationships, I was constantly manipulated and had to explain everything I did. With [Partner's Name], I don't have to explain my actions all the time. For example, if I go to [City] to visit family, I don't worry about how to explain it to [Partner's Name]. This creates a sense of security. I don't have to justify my actions, and there's no manipulation. This level of trust and understanding is what I mean by a safe space.

Speaker 1 [00:37:07] How important is aşk in a relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:37:15] I don't know. Since I've questioned the societal construct of aşk, it's a hard question. Aşk might be important for giving love and care, but it's not the only thing. Mutual respect and care are also crucial.

Speaker 1 [00:38:31] How do you know your partner loves you?

Speaker 2 [00:38:38] I know through the care and consideration [Partner's Name] shows. It's not about saying "I love you" but about respecting my space, not hurting me, and truly listening to me.

Speaker 1 [00:39:15] Can you give concrete examples of this care?

Speaker 2 [00:39:24] Care is not just about saying "I love you" or giving gifts. It's about respecting my space, not hurting me, and genuinely listening to me. For example, [Partner's Name] doesn't push me to explain everything and creates a safe space for me to express myself.

Speaker 1 [00:40:26] What challenges do you face in your relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:40:34] We don't have many specific challenges right now. In the beginning, there was some confusion about how to handle our open relationship. We had to figure out boundaries and how to communicate openly. Now, physical distance can be a challenge when I visit my family, but we manage it by staying connected through calls and understanding each other's needs.

Speaker 1 [00:42:42] Do you and your partner argue?

Speaker 2 [00:42:48] If you mean shouting matches, no. We have moments of tension, but we manage them by giving each other space and then talking about it calmly. We've only had a few significant tensions in [1-5] years, mostly in the early complicated times.

Speaker 1 [00:44:19] How do you resolve these tensions?

Speaker 2 [00:45:06] Mostly by talking. It doesn't have to be immediate; we can discuss it later. In previous relationships, arguments would stop everything, but now we give each other space to calm down and then talk. This way, we don't let arguments disrupt our lives.

Speaker 1 [00:46:57] Besides open communication, what other ways do you maintain your relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:47:06] Staying calm. Not reacting in the heat of the moment helps prevent harm. It's about giving each other space to cool down and then discussing things rationally.

Speaker 1 [00:47:44] Do you think this relationship is good for you?

Speaker 2 [00:47:48] Definitely.

Speaker 1 [00:47:50] Why do you think so?

Speaker 2 [00:47:53] Because it doesn't feel like a job. In past relationships, I felt like I had to work constantly to maintain them. Now, it's effortless and doesn't drain me. We don't pressure each other, and I feel secure and respected.

Speaker 1 [00:51:06] Has this relationship changed you?

Speaker 2 [00:51:11] In every way. I'm much more at peace and calmer. I don't feel like I'm constantly fighting or proving myself. This relationship has opened my mind and given me a sense of security and growth.

Speaker 1 [00:52:11] Do you think your partner has changed during this relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:52:18] I think so. Based on my observations, [Partner's Name] has become calmer too. his communication with his family has improved, and he doesn't feel the need to explain himself constantly. This mutual respect and understanding have benefited both of us.

Speaker 1 [00:55:09] Do you feel secure in this relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:55:13] Very much so.

Speaker 1 [00:55:14] Why do you say that? Can you elaborate?

Speaker 2 [00:55:21] Because I know [Partner's Name] wouldn't intentionally harm me. Even if something hurtful is said, I know it's not meant to harm me. This understanding creates a secure environment where we don't fear each other's reactions.

Speaker 1 [00:56:11] Now, I will share a screen with you.

Speaker 2 [00:56:14] Okay.

Speaker 1 [00:56:21] On a scale of 1 to 9, where 1 is not at all true and 9 is completely true, how would you rate "My partner generally listens to me"?

Speaker 2 [00:56:45] Nine.

Speaker 1 [00:56:46] Why did you rate it nine?

Speaker 2 [00:56:57] Because [Partner's Name] is the best at communicating with me. he listens without manipulating what I say. I can express myself without having to explain or justify my feelings.

Speaker 1 [00:57:18] Can you give examples of when you felt truly listened to?

Speaker 2 [00:57:32] Recently, an ex-partner made some hurtful comments that affected me deeply. I shared my feelings with [Partner's Name], and he listened without

judgment. he offered him support and gave me the space to express my emotions. This level of understanding and respect made me feel truly heard.

Speaker 1 [00:58:49] On a scale of 1 to 9, where 1 is not at all true and 9 is completely true, how would you rate “My partner is generally sensitive to my needs”?

Speaker 2 [00:58:57] Nine.

Speaker 1 [00:58:57] Why did you rate it nine?

Speaker 2 [00:59:29] Because, for example, when I miss my family or need some time alone, [Partner's Name] respects that without question. he understands my needs and doesn't make me feel guilty for taking time for myself.

Speaker 1 [00:59:29] Now, if you don't mind, could you tell us more about your physical closeness as a couple? How often do you have sex these days?

Speaker 2 [00:59:47] Recently, not as much due to my physical issues. I have a herniated disc, which has been very painful for the past few months. We had sex [1-5] times last month. Normally, we're more active, but my physical pain and work stress have limited it.

Speaker 1 [01:00:42] How satisfied are you with your sex life?

Speaker 2 [01:00:46] Very satisfied. We've reached a very open and explorative point. I have a more masculine identity, and past partners were less open. [Partner's Name] has opened my mind to different experiences, and we've explored a lot together, including new toys. Even with my physical issues, our sex life is fulfilling and liberating.

Speaker 1 [01:02:40] How important is sexuality in a relationship for you?

Speaker 2 [01:02:47] It depends on the partner. My previous partner didn't understand my work stress and took it personally when I couldn't be as active. With [Partner's Name], there's no pressure. he understands my physical limitations and supports me. So, while sexuality is important, the partner's understanding makes a big difference.

Speaker 1 [01:03:50] Now, I will share another screen with you. How satisfied are you with your relationship overall?

Speaker 2 [01:04:04] Completely satisfied.

Speaker 1 [01:04:06] Alright. How would you rate your relationship satisfaction on a scale of 0 to 10?

Speaker 2 [01:04:15] Ten.

Speaker 1 [01:04:19] Why did you rate it ten?

Speaker 2 [01:04:23] Because this relationship feels effortless and secure. It doesn't feel like a job, and I don't feel pressured or unsafe. Even if there are small issues, we talk about them and resolve them. I feel very lucky and content with my relationship.

Speaker 1 [01:05:21] Has this relationship met your expectations?

Speaker 2 [01:05:27] I didn't even have these expectations because I wasn't aware of how much I was missing in past relationships. [Partner's Name] has exceeded my expectations by providing a safe, respectful, and open relationship.

Speaker 1 [01:06:04] To conclude, I'd like to summarize what we've discussed in the past hour. Please let me know if anything is incorrect or if there's anything you'd like to add.

Speaker 2 [01:06:12] I've talked a lot, haven't I? I hope it's helpful.

Speaker 1 [01:06:14] Absolutely. Thank you. It's been very insightful. We started with demographic questions: you're [30-35] and have been in a relationship for [1-5] years. You live with your family but also with your partner in [City]. Your main income is from [occupation]. You met through an [community]. During a period of personal upheaval, mutual support and open communication helped your relationship evolve. Compared to your friends' relationships, you feel lucky due to the open communication and lack of jealousy. In past relationships, you experienced psychological abuse and lack of support. In this relationship, you have open communication, respect, and understanding. You discussed how societal constructs of aşk and sevgi influenced your past relationships. Currently, you see aşk as genuinely liking someone and having a safe, peaceful space with them. You rate your relationship satisfaction as ten because it's effortless and secure. You feel it has changed you for the better, making you more peaceful and open-minded. You also believe it has positively changed your partner. You feel safe and listened to, and your needs are respected. Your sex life, though limited recently by physical issues, is fulfilling and explorative. Overall, you're completely satisfied with your relationship. Do you have anything to add or correct?

Speaker 2 [01:11:25] No, that sounds perfect. Hearing it summarized makes me realize how valuable this relationship is. Thank you.

Speaker 1 [01:11:25] Before we finish, I'd like to discuss how we handle your data. We aim to be as transparent as possible and want to know which sharing option you prefer. The first option is sharing anonymized excerpts from our interview, ensuring no identifying information is included. The second option is sharing the full anonymized transcript, with all sensitive details removed. This might allow someone who knows you well to identify you, but the chances are very low. Which option do you prefer?

Speaker 2 [01:12:29] You can share everything. I trust you to anonymize it properly. I'm okay with that.

Speaker 1 [01:12:29] Thank you again for participating. This project spans multiple countries and your insights are invaluable. To help us reach more participants, could



you suggest two close friends as potential candidates? We won't ask them to participate directly but to recommend other couples. Is that alright?

Speaker 2 [01:13:39] I have one couple in mind. I'll talk to them and let you know.

Speaker 1 [01:14:05] Great. I'll send you a survey to fill out after this call. It takes about 10 minutes. Thank you so much for your time and insights.

Speaker 2 [01:14:56] Thank you. It was a pleasure.